

ADHD-FRIENDLY · SHAME-FREE · 7 DAYS

The Messy Brain Home Reset

A shame-free, ADHD-friendly system to get your home under control in 7 days — and keep it there.

today's reset

15:00

- ☒ Trash bag lap
- ☒ Everything else in one basket
- ☒ Clear one surface
- ☐ Celebrate (required)

*small steps.
zero shame.
a home that works.*

The Messy Brain Home Reset

A shame-free, ADHD-friendly system to get your home under control in 7 days — and keep it there.

● THE FRIENDLY FINE PRINT

This book is not medical advice. It's practical home-organizing ideas from people whose brains work a lot like yours. It isn't a substitute for diagnosis, treatment, or support from a doctor or mental-health professional. If things feel heavy beyond the dishes, please reach out to someone qualified. You deserve that support.

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Examples of times, ages, and tasks in this book are general suggestions, not rules. Every home and every brain is different, so adjust anything to fit yours. Use cleaning products as their labels direct, and never mix them.

Made with care (and several timers) for busy, beautiful, messy brains.

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● **BRAIN FULL?**

Read **only page 4**, the 1-Page Quick Start. It's allowed. Everything else can wait.

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Start Here: The 1-Page Quick Start

Brain too full to read a whole book right now? Same. Do these five things, in order. Then close this book with zero guilt. The rest will be here when you're ready.

- 1 Set a timer for 15 minutes.** Put on one song you love. Loud is fine. You're allowed to stop the moment the timer rings.
- 2 Grab a trash bag.** Walk through the room you're in and pick up *only* trash. Wrappers, receipts, empty cups, mystery bits. Nothing else. No decisions yet.
- 3 Grab a laundry basket.** Everything that doesn't live in this room goes in the basket. Don't deliver anything anywhere. The basket is doing the walking today.
- 4 Pick one surface and clear it completely.** One. Kitchen counter, coffee table, or nightstand. Wipe it. Put back only what earns its spot.
- 5 When the timer rings, stop.** Look at that clear surface for a full five seconds. That's the whole method in miniature: small, timed, visible, done.

● THEN WHAT?

Tomorrow: turn to the 7-Day Reset on page 21 and do Day 1's *minimum version*. That's it. One day at a time, one zone at a time.

Someone coming over? Skip to the 15-Minute Emergency Reset on page 17.

Fell off the wagon (again)? The Restart Protocol on page 59 was written for you.

You don't need to read this book in order. You don't need to finish it. You're allowed to use it like a menu.

Hi, Messy Brain. Welcome in.

If your home looks like a tornado that got bored halfway through, and you've spent more hours *feeling bad* about the mess than cleaning it, you're in the right place.

This book is not going to tell you to wake up at 5 a.m., color-code your spices, or "clean as you go." (If "clean as you go" worked for us, we'd already be doing it.)

Instead, you'll get **a small, forgiving system built for how our brains actually work**: we lose track of what we can't see, we struggle to start, we get tired from tiny decisions, we have no idea how long anything takes, and we tend to do things all the way or not at all.

That's not a flaw you need to fix before you can have a nice home. **It's the design brief.**

What this book promises (and what it doesn't)

● WHAT YOU'LL GET

- ✓ A home that's **functional most days**, not spotless some days
- ✓ A plan for **the next 7 days**, with a tiny version for rough days
- ✓ Systems that **catch the mess before it becomes a disaster**
- ✓ A way back in, every single time you fall off

What you won't get: a perfect home. Perfect homes are for magazines and people with staff. We're going for **"I could have a friend over with 15 minutes' notice and not want to move to another country."**

How to read this book when you can't focus

- **Read the Quick Start (previous page). Only that.** Seriously. It's allowed.
- **Skip around.** Every chapter works on its own. The opener page of each chapter has an *"If you only read one thing"* box. Reading only those boxes is a legit way to read this book.
- **Look for the colored boxes.** They're the good bits:

BRAIN NOTE

Why our brains do the thing.

TRY THIS NOW

A tiny action, under 5 minutes.

MINIMUM VERSION

The low-energy version that still counts.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Kind words for you and your people.

- **Write in it.** Tick the boxes. Scribble in the margins. Print the checklists at the back and stick them on the fridge.
- **Stop when you're tired.** Nothing in here expires.

● A NOTE ON WORDS

You'll notice some words are missing from this book. There's no "lazy," no "should have," no "just do it." Those words never cleaned a single kitchen. Around here, **we deal in systems, not shame.**

The one-sentence version of this whole book

**Make it visible, make it small, set a timer, and let
"done" be good enough.**

Ready? Take a breath. Let's go look at why the old advice never stuck — so you can finally stop blaming yourself for it.

01

CHAPTER 1

Why Normal Cleaning Advice Fails Our Brains

It was never a character flaw. It was a design flaw.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Most cleaning advice assumes you can **see** mess, **start** easily, **decide** fast, **feel** time passing, and happily do things **halfway**. If those are hard for you, the advice was built for someone else. This book builds around those five things instead of fighting them.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The advice vs. what our brains hear
- 1. Out of sight, out of mind
- 2. The starting problem
- 3. Decision fatigue
- 4. Time blindness
- 5. All-or-nothing
- Bonus: the boredom wall
- The shame loop (and where we break it)

Here's a secret the tidy people never told us: most cleaning advice is written by people whose brains quietly do half the work for them. Their brains *notice* the mail pile. Their brains *nudge* them to start. Their brains *decide* where the scissors go without a committee meeting.

Many of us with ADHD don't get those free nudges. So we read the same advice, try it, crash, and decide the problem is us.

It isn't. Let's translate.

The advice vs. what our brains hear

THE ADVICE	WHAT OUR BRAIN HEARS	WHAT WE DO INSTEAD
"Clean as you go."	"Remember, at every moment, to notice mess you've stopped seeing."	Clean at set reset points with a timer.
"A place for everything."	"Invent 400 places. Remember all of them."	Homes where you drop stuff anyway , labeled.
"Do a little every day."	"Do an unclear amount of an unclear thing, forever."	The Daily 3 : three named, tiny resets.
"Tidy up before bed."	"At your most tired, do your hardest task."	A 2-minute launch pad check, that's it.
"Deep clean on the weekend."	"Spend your whole Saturday dreading one task."	Reset, don't deep clean. In 15-minute rounds.

Now let's meet the five brain things that make housework feel harder for us. Knowing them is half the fix, because once you know *why* the mail piles up, you can stop taking it personally and start designing around it.

1. Out of sight, out of mind

Lots of ADHD folks describe it the same way: **if I can't see it, it stops existing**. The clean towels in the closet? Gone. The bill in the drawer? Never heard of it. The produce in the crisper drawer? Now a science project.

And the flip side: the stuff we *can* see, we stop seeing after a few days. The mail pile blends into the wallpaper. That's why "put things away" advice backfires. Put away often means *disappear*.

● BRAIN NOTE

This is why people with messy-brain homes often have **piles instead of drawers**. Piles are a clever workaround: they keep things visible. The problem isn't the pile instinct. It's that piles have no system. We'll give them one.

The fix: visible storage (clear bins, hooks, open baskets, labels), and **reset points** that make you look at your space on purpose.

2. The starting problem

You know the feeling. You *want* to do the dishes. You're standing right there. And somehow your body won't start. It's like there's an invisible wall of awful between you and the task.

That wall is real, and it's not about willpower. For a lot of us, **starting is the hardest part of any task**, far harder than the task itself. Once we're moving, we're often fine. Sometimes we're even great.

The fix: make the start ridiculously small and oddly specific. Not "clean the kitchen." Instead: *"put five forks in the dishwasher."* Plus a timer, so the brain knows there's an end. Plus company (a body double), so it's easier to begin.

● TRY THIS NOW

Say out loud, the smallest possible start of a task you're avoiding: *"I'm going to carry one mug to the kitchen."* Then do only that. Notice what happens next. (Often: a second mug.)

3. Decision fatigue

Every object on a messy counter is a tiny question. *Keep it? Where does it go? Is that where it goes? Should I have a place for this? What even is this?*

Fifty objects is fifty questions. By question twelve, the brain taps out and suddenly you're on your phone, or reorganizing a drawer that wasn't even the problem.

The fix: make decisions *once*, in advance, so tidying becomes putting things where they already go. The 5-bin method (Chapter 7) and the decision scripts in this book exist so you never have to argue with a sock again.

4. Time blindness

Our internal clocks are... creative. A task we hate feels like it will take three hours. A task we love eats three hours and feels like ten minutes.

So "unload the dishwasher" gets filed as a Big Awful Job, when for many of us it takes around five minutes. And "I'll quickly tidy before I leave" becomes being late. Again.

The fix: timers everywhere, and a fun little experiment called "**Time it once.**" Time the tasks you dread. Write the real number down. The dread usually shrinks when you see it.

● TRY THIS NOW

Next time you unload the dishwasher or fold a load of laundry, start a stopwatch. Write the time on a sticky note and put it where you do the task. It becomes a tiny argument-winner for future you: *"It's only 6 minutes."*

5. All-or-nothing

Our brains love extremes. Either the whole house gets cleaned top to bottom in a heroic, snack-fueled 9-hour sprint... or nothing happens for three weeks.

The problem is that the heroic sprint is so exhausting that the brain files cleaning under *"never again."* And "a little bit" feels pointless, so we skip it.

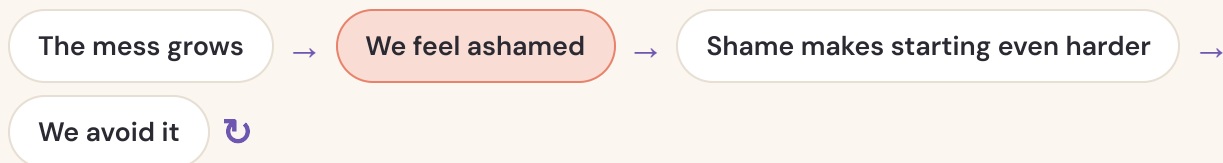
The fix: every task in this book has a **minimum version** that still counts. Doing 10% is not failing. **Doing 10% is the system working.**

Bonus: the boredom wall

Housework is repetitive, and many of our brains run on interest, novelty, urgency, or challenge more than on importance. That's why you can clean the whole kitchen when a friend is 20 minutes away (urgency!) but not on a quiet Tuesday.

The fix: borrow the good stuff on purpose. Race a song. Set a "beat the timer" challenge. Put on a podcast you only allow yourself during cleaning. Clean while on the phone with a friend. We're not above bribing ourselves. We're smart enough to.

The shame loop (and where we break it)



Shame feels like motivation, but it works like a brake. The more awful you feel about the kitchen, the harder it is to walk into the kitchen.

So we break the loop at the shame part. Not by pretending the mess isn't there, but by treating it like what it is: **information**. A pile by the door means "stuff needs a home by the door." A clothes chair means "worn-once clothes need a home." Mess is your house telling you where the systems are missing.

● SAY IT LIKE THIS (TO YOURSELF)

"This isn't a character problem. It's a systems problem. And systems can be fixed in 15 minutes at a time."

02

CHAPTER 2

The 6 House Rules

Six little rules that quietly do the heavy lifting.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Reset, don't deep clean. Visible beats hidden. Every thing gets a home, every home gets a label. Done beats perfect. Touch it once. Never clean alone without a timer. If you remember nothing else, remember these six.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Rule 1: Reset, don't deep clean
- Rule 2: Visible beats hidden
- Rule 3: Every thing gets a home, every home gets a label
- Rule 4: Done beats perfect
- Rule 5: Touch it once
- Rule 6: Body double + timer
- The rule under all the rules

These rules are the backbone of everything else in this book. You don't need to memorize them. They'll keep showing up until they feel obvious. There's also a copy on the printable Quick Start card at the back.

Rule 1: Reset, don't deep clean

A **reset** means putting a space back to *usable*: counters clear enough to cook, floor clear enough to walk, bed clear enough to sleep. That's the goal. Not sparkling. Usable.

Deep cleaning (scrubbing grout, wiping baseboards, organizing the linen closet) is nice. It's also a trap for our all-or-nothing brains, because it's huge, and it makes the everyday stuff feel pointless by comparison.

What it looks like: you walk into the kitchen at 9 p.m. and instead of thinking "this whole kitchen is disgusting," you think "reset: dishes in, counters clear, wipe, done."

● BRAIN NOTE

A clean-enough home every day beats a perfect home once a month. Deep cleaning can happen later, a little at a time, once the resets are easy. Most weeks, the resets *are* the cleaning.

Rule 2: Visible beats hidden

If out of sight is out of mind, then **in sight is in mind**. So we design for seeing.

- **Open baskets beat lidded bins.** A lid is one more step, and one more wall to hide behind.
- **Hooks beat hangers.** Hanging a coat on a hook is one move. A hanger is four.
- **Clear containers beat opaque ones,** especially in the fridge and pantry.
- **Open shelves beat deep drawers** for things you use often.
- **Keep one surface empty on purpose** so you notice when it fills up.

● TRY THIS NOW

Find one closed thing that keeps getting ignored: a drawer, a lidded bin, a cabinet. Take the lid off, or move its contents to an open basket. Done. That's a whole system upgrade.

Rule 3: Every thing gets a home, every home gets a label

Mess is mostly **things without homes**. Nobody leaves their toothbrush on the living room floor, because the toothbrush has a very clear home. The chaos lives in the in-between stuff: chargers, hair ties, tote bags, the weird cable.

Two tricks make homes work for us:

1. **Put the home where the thing already lands.** If your keys always end up on the kitchen counter, the key home goes *on the kitchen counter*. Don't fight the landing spot. Upgrade it.
2. **Label the home, not the thing.** A label on a basket that says "CHARGERS" does your remembering for you. Labels also help everyone else in your house put stuff back (more on that in Chapter 11).

● BRAIN NOTE

If a home is hard to reach (behind a door, under another thing, requires a step stool), the floor will become the home. **Easy beats pretty.** A basket on the floor labeled "SHOES" works better than a gorgeous shoe cabinet you never open.

Rule 4: Done beats perfect

Perfectionism and ADHD are old friends. It sounds like: *"If I can't do the whole thing properly, why bother?"* And then nothing gets done.

Around here we aim for **the B-minus clean**. Dishes in the dishwasher, even if it's not loaded like a Tetris champion. Laundry in a basket, even if it's not folded. A bed with the duvet pulled up, even if the pillows are a mess.

B-minus, every day, beats A-plus, never.

● SAY IT LIKE THIS

"Good enough is the goal. It's not settling. It's the strategy."

Rule 5: Touch it once

When you pick something up, **take it to its home, or to a basket that's headed there.** Try not to put it down "for now." *For now* is how piles are born.

We're realistic about this, though. Sometimes the thing's home is upstairs and you're in the middle of something. So we use a **"Going That Way" basket**: a basket that collects stuff for another room. When you're headed that way, the basket goes with you.

- Upstairs? A basket at the bottom of the stairs.
- Car? A tote by the door.
- Other rooms? One basket in the main room.

Rule of the basket: it gets emptied once a day, usually during your Daily 3 (page 35).

Rule 6: Body double + timer

Two tools that turn "I can't start" into "oh, I'm doing it":

A timer tells your brain the suffering has an end. "Clean the kitchen" is endless. "Clean for 12 minutes" is survivable. A visual timer (one where you can see the time shrinking) works especially well for a lot of us.

A body double is another person nearby while you do the task. They don't need to help. They can be:

- A friend on a video call, doing their own chores
- A partner reading on the couch in the same room
- A "clean with me" video playing on your phone
- A virtual coworking room
- Honestly, sometimes the dog counts

● BRAIN NOTE

Nobody fully agrees on why body doubling works so well for so many of us, but plenty of ADHD folks swear by it. Maybe it's gentle accountability. Maybe it's that another person makes the room feel "on." Either way: it's free, and it's worth a try.

The rule under all the rules

Be kind to the person doing the cleaning. That's you. You'll get more done as your own friend than as your own drill sergeant. Every time.

03

CHAPTER 3

The 15-Minute Emergency Reset

Someone's coming over. Don't panic. Grab a basket.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Only clean what they'll see. Walk the "guest path" (door, sitting spot, bathroom). Trash in a bag, everything else in one big basket, basket out of sight. Dishes in the sink, bathroom wiped, lamps on. Fifteen minutes. Then empty the basket within 48 hours so it doesn't become a new doom pile.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- What you need (grab these first, 30 seconds)
- The plan, minute by minute
- The 5-minute version (they're already parking)
- What NOT to do in an emergency
- Aftercare: the 48-hour basket rule

Your phone buzzes. "Hey! I'm in the area, can I pop by in 20?" Your heart drops into your socks. You look around. Every flat surface is wearing a hat of stuff.

This is the plan for that moment. It's also a great plan for any day you want fast, visible progress, because it's built on the one thing our brains do brilliantly: **urgency**.

What you need (grab these first, 30 seconds)

- **One trash bag**
- **One big "chaos basket"** (a laundry basket, a big tote, or a large bag)
- **Disinfecting wipes** or a damp cloth with a bit of soap
- **Your phone** with a 15-minute timer and a fast song

The plan, minute by minute

TIME	WHAT YOU DO
0:00–1:00	Walk the guest path. Stand at the front door and look in, like a visitor. Where will they walk? Where will they sit? Will they use the bathroom? That path is the <i>only</i> area you're cleaning.
1:00–4:00	Trash sweep. Trash bag in hand, walk the guest path and grab obvious trash only. Cups, wrappers, boxes, mail envelopes.
4:00–8:00	Chaos basket sweep. Everything that isn't trash and isn't where it lives goes in the basket. Floor first, then surfaces. Don't sort. Don't deliver. Basket goes in a bedroom, closet, or car trunk.
8:00–10:00	Dishes. Everything into the sink or dishwasher. Sink overflowing? Fill it with hot soapy water. A soaking sink looks <i>intentional</i> .
10:00–12:00	Bathroom blitz. Swish the toilet, wipe the seat and rim, wipe the sink. Fresh hand towel. Toilet paper within reach. Close the shower curtain. Done.
12:00–14:00	Wipe the sitting spot. Wipe the table they'll sit at. Fluff the couch cushions. Fold one blanket over the arm of the couch (instant "cozy on purpose").
14:00–15:00	Set the mood. Turn on lamps (warm light is very forgiving). Turn off harsh overhead lights. Open a window for a minute. Put on music. Breathe.

● WHY THIS WORKS

Guests don't see your home the way you do. You see every pile and remember every unfinished project. They see a lamp, a couch, and a friend. **The guest path is maybe a fifth of your home**, and that's all they'll notice.

The 5-minute version (they're already parking)

1. **Chaos basket** on the floor and the coffee table. Basket into a bedroom. Close the door.
2. **Dishes** into the sink, hot soapy water on top.
3. **Toilet** swish, seat wipe, fresh hand towel.
4. **Lamps on.**

That's it. You're a host now.

What NOT to do in an emergency

- **Don't start anything you might get stuck in.** No organizing drawers, no sorting mail, no "oh, I'll quickly fix this shelf." Emergencies are for hiding, not organizing.
- **Don't vacuum unless the floor is visibly crunchy.** It's loud, slow, and guests rarely notice floors.
- **Don't clean rooms they won't enter.** Close those doors with pride.
- **Don't apologize for your home when they walk in.** It makes guests feel like they need to reassure you, and it makes you feel worse.

● SAY IT LIKE THIS (INSTEAD OF APOLOGIZING)

"Come in! Want tea?"

That's the whole script. If you **really** need to say something: "**Welcome to our lived-in home!**" Cheerful, done, moving on.

Aftercare: the 48-hour basket rule

Here's the catch: the chaos basket is **not a home**. If it sits in the bedroom for a month, it becomes a doom pile with handles.

So within 48 hours:

- ☐ Set a 10-minute timer.
- ☐ Tip the basket out onto a bed or clear floor.
- ☐ Use the 5-bin method (page 48) or walk each thing to its home.
- ☐ Whatever's left when the timer rings goes back in the basket for one more round tomorrow.
- ☐ Basket back in its spot, empty and ready for next time.

● TRY THIS NOW

Choose your emergency chaos basket today and give it a permanent spot. Put a sticky note inside: *"Empty me within 48 hours."* Future you, with a guest arriving in 15 minutes, will be very grateful.

04

CHAPTER 4

The 7-Day Reset

One zone a day. One week. A home that works again.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Do one zone per day, in timed rounds, with a break between each round. Every day has a **minimum version** (10 minutes or less) that fully counts. If you miss a day, don't catch up. Pick up tomorrow's day with its minimum version and keep going.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- How the 7-Day Reset works
- The week at a glance
- The rules for this week
- Day 0: Gather your kit
- Day 1: The Kitchen (sink & counters)
- Day 2: The Living Room (floor & couch zone)
- Day 3: The Launch Pad
- Day 4: Laundry to Zero-ish
- Day 5: The Bedroom & the Clothes Chair
- Day 6: The Bathroom + the Paper Pile
- Day 7: One Doom Pile + the Victory Lap

Welcome to the main event. Over the next seven days, we'll reset the parts of your home that cause the most daily chaos, and put tiny systems in place so they stay reset.

How the 7-Day Reset works

One zone a day. Not the whole house. Your brain gets one job each day, and a finish line.

Timed rounds. Each day is split into rounds of 10 to 15 minutes with short breaks. You can do all the rounds at once, spread them through the day, or stop after one.

Three versions of every day:

Minimum

10 minutes or less. For low-energy days. Fully counts.

Standard

About 45 to 60 minutes in rounds. The full reset.

Bonus

Only if you're on a roll. Totally optional.

The order matters (a bit). We start with the kitchen because it changes the mood of the whole house fastest. Then we move through the spots where daily life gets stuck. But if one zone is on fire, it's okay to swap days around.

The week at a glance

DAY	ZONE	MINIMUM VERSION
Day 0	Gather your kit (15 min)	Find one basket and one trash bag
Day 1	The kitchen: sink & counters	Empty the sink, wipe one counter
Day 2	The living room: floor & couch zone	Clear the floor and the coffee table
Day 3	The launch pad by the door	One bowl for keys by the door
Day 4	Laundry to zero-ish	One load, all the way to the drawer
Day 5	Bedroom & the clothes chair	Make the bed, sort the chair into 3 piles
Day 6	Bathroom + the paper pile	Set up a wipe station, sort mail into 3
Day 7	One doom pile + victory lap	"After" photos + choose your Daily 3

The rules for this week

- **Skipping is allowed.** Missing a day is not failing the week. It's a normal week for a human.
- **Never double up.** Missed Day 3? Tomorrow is Day 4's minimum version, not a Day 3 + Day 4 marathon. (You can come back to Day 3 later, or never.)
- **Take "before" photos.** Our brains forget progress fast. Photos are proof.
- **Stop when the timer rings.** Even if you're on a roll. Especially if you're on a roll. Ending while it still feels okay makes tomorrow easier to start.
- **Celebrate every day.** Tick the box, text a friend, eat the good snack. Your brain learns from rewards, not lectures.

Day 0

Gather your kit

15 minutes

Do this the day before Day 1

Before we start, gather a small "reset kit." This is the difference between *"I'll start... wait, where are the trash bags?"* (and suddenly it's 45 minutes later and you're reorganizing the junk drawer) and actually starting.

Your reset kit:

- ☐ **A roll of trash bags**
- ☐ **One laundry basket** (your chaos basket / "Going That Way" basket)
- ☐ **Five boxes, bags, or bins** for decluttering, labeled: TRASH, DONATE, ELSEWHERE, KEEP, MAYBE (more on these on page 48)
- ☐ **A marker and some sticky notes or masking tape** for labels
- ☐ **Wipes or a spray bottle and cloth**
- ☐ **A timer** (your phone is fine; a visual timer is great)
- ☐ **A playlist** of fast, happy songs, or a podcast you like
- ☐ **This book**, and a pen

Put everything in one basket or tote, somewhere you'll see it tomorrow. That's your **reset caddy** for the week.

● MINIMUM VERSION

Find **one basket** and **one trash bag**. Put them by the kitchen. You're ready.

Day 1

The Kitchen (sink & counters)

Standard: 3 rounds of 15 min

Minimum: 10 min

Today's goal: an empty sink and at least one clear, wiped counter. **"Done" looks like:** you could make a sandwich without moving anything first.

ROUND	WHAT YOU DO
Round 1 15 min	Trash and dishes. Trash bag first: every wrapper, empty container, and dead produce. Then gather every dish in the house (yes, the bedroom mugs too) into the kitchen.
Break 5 min	Drink water. Sit down. Don't pick up your phone if you know it'll eat an hour. (Set a 5-minute timer if you do.)
Round 2 15 min	Load and soak. Fill the dishwasher (or a drying rack) with what fits. Everything else: stack by type next to the sink and soak crusty pans in hot soapy water. Run the dishwasher.
Break 5 min	Snack. Stretch. Look at how much less stuff is on the counter.
Round 3 15 min	Clear one counter completely. Everything off. Wipe it. Put back only what you use every day. Everything else goes to its home, or into the chaos basket for later.

● THE SORTED-DISH TRICK

A sink of mixed dishes is a hundred tiny decisions. A counter with **all the cups together, all the plates together, all the forks in one mug** is three easy tasks. Sorting first makes washing feel smaller. Try it once and see.

● MINIMUM VERSION

Empty the sink (dishwasher, drying rack, or stacked neatly beside it with the crusty stuff soaking) and **wipe one counter**. Ten minutes. Counts completely.

Day 1 checklist

- ☐ Trash bag round done
- ☐ All the dishes are in the kitchen
- ☐ Dishwasher running (or rack full)
- ☐ Sink empty

- ☐ One counter clear and wiped
- ☐ "After" photo taken
- ☐ *Bonus*: stovetop wiped, trash out
- ☐ Celebrated (required!)

Day 2

The Living Room (floor & couch zone)

Standard: 3 rounds of 12 min

Minimum: 10 min

Today's goal: a clear floor and a clear coffee table. **"Done" looks like:** you could sit on the couch with a cup of tea and nothing is poking you.

Here's a secret about rooms: **a clear floor makes a room feel much tidier than clear shelves do.** The floor is the biggest surface your eyes see. Clear it first, and the rest suddenly looks manageable.

ROUND	WHAT YOU DO
Round 1 12 min	Trash, dishes, laundry. Three quick passes around the room. Pass one: trash. Pass two: dishes to the kitchen. Pass three: clothes into a laundry basket.
Break 5 min	You've already made a visible difference. Look around.
Round 2 12 min	The floor. Everything on the floor goes to one of three places: its home in this room, the "Going That Way" basket, or the MAYBE box. Don't reorganize anything. Only lift and place.
Break 5 min	Deliver the "Going That Way" basket to other rooms, if you feel like it. If not, leave it by the door.
Round 3 12 min	The couch zone. Clear the coffee table and couch. Wipe the table. Fold blankets. Fluff cushions. Put remotes, chargers, and lip balm in one small basket or tray on the table.

● THE "COUCH CADDY"

Every living room collects the same little things: remotes, chargers, hair ties, lip balm, a pen. Give them **one small tray or basket** on the coffee table. Now "tidying the table" means dropping those bits in one place, not finding five homes for five things.

● MINIMUM VERSION

Clear the floor (into a basket if needed) **and the coffee table.** Leave everything else. The room will already feel lighter.

Day 2 checklist

- ☐ Trash pass done
- ☐ Dishes back in the kitchen
- ☐ Clothes in the laundry basket
- ☐ Floor clear
- ☐ Coffee table clear and wiped
- ☐ Couch caddy set up
- ☐ "Going That Way" basket delivered (or parked by the door)
- ☐ Celebrated

Day 3

The Launch Pad

Standard: 2 rounds of 15 min

Minimum: 5 min

Today's goal: one spot by the door where your keys, bag, and outgoing stuff always live.

"Done" looks like: tomorrow morning you walk out the door without a single *"where are my keys?!"*

The launch pad is the single most life-changing system in this book for a lot of us. It stops the morning scramble, and it keeps the stuff you bring in from spreading through the house. (Full details on page 40.)

ROUND	WHAT YOU DO
Round 1 15 min	Clear the landing zone. Look at where stuff lands when you walk in (the table by the door, the kitchen counter, the floor). Clear that spot. Shoes to one place, bags to one place, trash out.
Break 5 min	Walk around the house and collect keys, wallet, sunglasses, work badge, earbuds. Bring them all to the landing zone.
Round 2 15 min	Build the pad. One bowl or tray for keys and wallet. One hook for your bag. One spot for shoes. One basket or bag labeled OUT for things that need to leave the house (returns, library books, things to give back). Label everything.

● BRAIN NOTE

Build the launch pad **where stuff already lands**, even if it's the "wrong" spot, like the kitchen counter. You're not trying to change your habits. You're giving your existing habit a home.

● MINIMUM VERSION

Put **one bowl** right where you walk in. Drop your keys in it. That's a launch pad. You can add the rest later.

Day 3 checklist

- ☐ Landing zone cleared
- ☐ Keys, wallet, and daily bits collected
- ☐ Key bowl or tray in place
- ☐ Bag hook in place
- ☐ Shoe spot chosen
- ☐ OUT basket set up and labeled
- ☐ Keys are in the bowl right now
- ☐ Celebrated

Day 4

Laundry to Zero-ish

Standard: a full day of short check-ins

Minimum: 1 load

Today's goal: every piece of dirty laundry is in a hamper, and at least one load has gone *all the way* to the drawer. **"Done" looks like:** no clean-laundry mountain, and no forgotten wet load in the washer.

Laundry is a sneaky one, because it has **five separate steps** (gather, wash, dry, fold, put away) spread across hours. Our brains lose the thread somewhere around step three. Today we practice the full loop, with alarms. (The whole laundry loop system is on page 40.)

ROUND	WHAT YOU DO
Round 1 15 min	Gather and start. Collect every dirty item from every room into hampers or baskets. Sort into only two piles: <i>darks</i> and <i>lights</i> . Start the biggest pile. Set an alarm named "WET CLOTHES" for when the cycle ends.
Alarm	Switch. Wet clothes into the dryer or onto a rack. Start the next load. New alarm: "DRY CLOTHES".
Round 2 15 min	Tackle the clean mountain. If you have a pile of clean clothes, sort it into people or categories (not folding yet, only sorting). Put an episode of something on.
Alarm	Fold only what needs folding. Put it away <i>right now</i> , before anything else. That's what "all the way" means.

● THE NO-FOLD LIST

You're allowed to never fold these again: **underwear, socks, pajamas, gym clothes, kids' clothes, dish towels.** Give each category a bin or drawer and toss them in. Folding is optional. Putting away is the real finish line.

● MINIMUM VERSION

One load, all the way. Wash, dry, put away. Even if the rest of the laundry is still a mountain, you've practiced the full loop, which is the whole point.

Day 4 checklist

- ☐ All dirty laundry gathered
- ☐ Sorted into two piles (that's it!)
- ☐ Load 1 washed, dried, put away
- ☐ Alarms used for every switch
- ☐ No-fold bins chosen
- ☐ Clean mountain smaller than this morning
- ☐ Celebrated

Day 5

The Bedroom & the Clothes Chair

Standard: 3 rounds of 12 min

Minimum: 10 min

Today's goal: a made bed, a clear nightstand, and a clothes chair that's a chair again. **"Done" looks like:** you could climb into bed tonight without moving anything off it.

You probably have a clothes chair. (Or a clothes floor. Or a clothes treadmill.) It's not a failure.

It's a sign that "worn once, not dirty" clothes have no home. Today, we give them one.

ROUND	WHAT YOU DO
Round 1 12 min	Bed and floor. Make the bed the 30-second way: pull the duvet up, toss the pillows on top. Then trash, dishes, and clothes off the floor.
Break 5 min	Lie on your freshly made bed for a minute. You earned it.
Round 2 12 min	The clothes chair triage. Three piles only: <i>Dirty</i> (to the hamper), <i>Clean, never worn</i> (put away), <i>Worn once, wear again</i> (to the new "wear again" home: see below).
Break 5 min	Water. Stretch. Take an "after" photo of the chair.
Round 3 12 min	Nightstand. Clear it. Put back only a lamp, a small tray for the bedside bits (lip balm, hair tie, glasses), and whatever you read. Wipe it.

● THE "WEAR AGAIN" HOME

Put **two or three hooks** on the wall or back of the door, or place **one open basket** by the bed. Label it WEAR AGAIN. Now the jeans you wore once have somewhere to go that isn't the chair. (You can keep the chair too. It's a nice chair.)

● MINIMUM VERSION

Make the bed the 30-second way and **sort the clothes chair into 3 piles.** Stop there.

Day 5 checklist

- ☐ Bed made (30-second version is perfect)
- ☐ Floor clear
- ☐ Clothes chair sorted into 3 piles
- ☐ "Wear again" home set up
- ☐ Nightstand cleared, tray in place
- ☐ Celebrated

Day 6

The Bathroom + the Paper Pile

Standard: 2 rounds of 15 min each zone

Minimum: 10 min

Today's goal: a bathroom that's easy to wipe in two minutes, and a mail pile that's been sorted. **"Done" looks like:** your bathroom has its own cleaning kit, and you know where every bill is.

Two smaller zones today, because both of them mostly need *set-up*, not scrubbing.

ROUND	WHAT YOU DO
Round 1 15 min	Bathroom reset. Trash out. Clear the counter: only daily-use items stay. Wipe the sink, faucet, and mirror. Swish the toilet, wipe the seat. Fresh towels.
Round 2 10 min	Build the wipe station. Put wipes (or spray and a cloth), a toilet brush, and a spare roll of toilet paper <i>inside the bathroom</i> , where you can see them. If your supplies live in another room, you'll never use them.
Break 5 min	Snack break. Put on a new song or episode.
Round 3 15 min	Paper pile triage. Grab every loose paper, envelope, and letter. Stand over the recycling bin. Sort into only three folders: ACT (needs doing), PAY (bills), KEEP (important, file later). Junk goes straight in the recycling.

● BRAIN NOTE

Paper is **decision fatigue in envelope form**. Each piece is a question. That's why we only sort into three folders, and why the folders live somewhere visible (a wall pocket or a standing file on the counter), not in a drawer where they'll vanish. Full paper system on page 40.

● MINIMUM VERSION

Put wipes in the bathroom where you can see them, and **sort the mail into three piles:** act, pay, keep. Done.

Day 6 checklist

- ☐ Bathroom trash out
- ☐ Counter cleared to daily items
- ☐ Sink, toilet, mirror wiped
- ☐ Wipe station set up inside the bathroom
- ☐ Mail sorted into ACT / PAY / KEEP
- ☐ Junk mail recycled
- ☐ Celebrated

Day 7

One Doom Pile + the Victory Lap

Standard: 3 rounds of 12 min

Minimum: 10 min

Today's goal: one doom pile gone, and a plan for keeping all this going. **"Done" looks like:** you've chosen your Daily 3, and you can see a week of progress in your photos.

A **doom pile** is that stack of mixed stuff that's been sitting there so long it's become furniture. (DOOM: *Didn't Organize, Only Moved.*) You probably have a few. Today we pick **one**. Only one.

ROUND	WHAT YOU DO
Round 1 12 min	Pick your doom pile. The smallest one is a great choice. Grab your 5 bins. Work from the top: pick up, decide, drop. No reading, no testing pens, no "oh, I forgot about this" rabbit holes.
Break 5 min	Take the trash out. Put the donate bag in your car or by the door.
Round 2 12 min	Finish or stop. Keep going until the pile is gone, or the timer rings. Whatever's left goes in the MAYBE box with today's date on it.
Break 5 min	Deliver the ELSEWHERE bin, room by room.
Round 3 12 min	Victory lap. Walk your home. Take "after" photos from the same spots as your "before" photos. Then choose your Daily 3 (next chapter) and write them on a sticky note on the fridge.

● MINIMUM VERSION

Take your "after" photos and choose your Daily 3. Put them side by side with the "before" photos. Look at what you did in a week.

Day 7 checklist

- ☐ One doom pile gone (or smaller!)
- ☐ Trash and donations out of the house
- ☐ ELSEWHERE bin delivered
- ☐ "After" photos taken
- ☐ Daily 3 chosen and posted
- ☐ **Big celebration.** You finished a whole week. Tell someone.

● YOU DID A WHOLE WEEK

Maybe you did every standard version. Maybe you did three minimum versions and skipped four days. **Both are a win.** You've got a reset kit, a launch pad, a laundry loop, a wipe station, and proof that small works. Now let's keep it that way, with only three tiny things a day.

05

CHAPTER 5

The Daily 3

Three tiny resets a day. That's the whole maintenance plan.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Every day, do three small resets: (1) the Kitchen Closing Shift, (2) a 10-minute tidy of your main room, (3) a 2-minute launch pad check for tomorrow. Attach each one to something you already do. **One out of three still counts**, and on rough days the Daily 1 is enough.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Meet your Daily 3
- Reset 1: The Kitchen Closing Shift
- Reset 2: The 10-Minute Tidy
- Reset 3: Tomorrow-You Prep
- Stack them onto things you already do
- Make it your own
- How we count (the streak that doesn't break)

The 7-Day Reset got your home back. The Daily 3 keeps it. It's the smallest amount of daily effort that stops the mess from snowballing.

No schedules. No 20-item chore charts. Three named resets, each 10 minutes or less.

Meet your Daily 3

1

The Kitchen Closing Shift

Dishes in, counters clear, sink empty.

About 10 min.

2

The 10-Minute Tidy

Floor and surfaces of your main room.

10 min, timer on.

3

Tomorrow-You Prep

Launch pad check and one thing set out.

2 min.

Reset 1: The Kitchen Closing Shift

Restaurants don't close by "cleaning as they go." They have a **closing shift**: a short, fixed list done every night. Your kitchen gets one too.

1. **Dishes in** the dishwasher or rack (or stacked by the sink, crusty ones soaking).
2. **Counters cleared** of anything that isn't a daily-use item.
3. **Wipe** the counters and stovetop.
4. **Sink empty.** Run the dishwasher if it's full.
5. **Close the kitchen.** Hang a fresh towel, turn off the light. Kitchen's closed.

The full system (with a troubleshooting section for tiny kitchens and big families) is on page 40.

Reset 2: The 10-Minute Tidy

Pick the room you spend the most time in. Set a 10-minute timer. Then, in this order:

1. **Trash** out
2. **Dishes** to the kitchen
3. **Floor** clear (floor first, it has the biggest visual impact)

4. **Surfaces** clear-ish: stuff back to its home, or into the "Going That Way" basket
5. **Deliver** the basket, if there's time

When the timer rings: **stop**. Even mid-pile. The goal isn't a finished room. It's a room that never gets more than a day's worth of messy.

Reset 3: Tomorrow-You Prep

Two minutes at the launch pad, ideally before bed or while the kettle boils:

- **Keys, wallet, phone charger** in their spots?
- **Bag** packed for tomorrow?
- **Anything that needs to leave the house** in the OUT basket?
- **One thing set out** for the morning (clothes, gym bag, lunch container)?

That's it. Morning you will feel like someone looked after them. Because someone did.

Stack them onto things you already do

The Daily 3 works best when it's glued to a habit you already have, so you don't have to *remember* it. Some ideas:

RESET	GLUE IT TO...
Kitchen Closing Shift	Right after dinner, before you sit down. Or while the kettle boils for your evening tea.
10-Minute Tidy	Before you turn on the TV. During the first ten minutes of a podcast. When the kids start bath time.
Tomorrow-You Prep	After brushing your teeth. When you plug in your phone at night.

● TRY THIS NOW

Write your three resets on a sticky note, **each with its glue**. For example: *"After dinner: kitchen closing shift. Before TV: 10-min tidy. After teeth: launch pad."* Stick it on the fridge at eye level.

Make it your own

The default Daily 3 works for a lot of people, but your home might need a different three. Swap in whatever causes the most chaos in *your* house:

- **Laundry chaos?** Swap Reset 2 for *"one load, all the way"* (start it in the morning, put it away at night).
- **Kids' toys everywhere?** Make Reset 2 a *"toy rescue"*: everything back in bins before bath time, set to one song.
- **Pets?** Add a 2-minute floor sweep in the spot where the fur gathers.
- **Work from home?** Swap Reset 3 for *"close the office"*: clear the desk, shut the laptop, push in the chair.

How we count (the streak that doesn't break)

Here's the scoring system:

- **3 out of 3:** a great day.
- **2 out of 3:** a great day.
- **1 out of 3:** still a great day.
- **0 out of 3:** a day off. Tomorrow is a new day. No catching up.

Track **days with at least one reset**, not perfect days. That's a streak that bends instead of breaks.

● THE DAILY 1 (FOR ROUGH DAYS)

On days when everything is hard, do only the **Kitchen Closing Shift's first step: dishes in the sink or dishwasher**. That's it. It keeps the most important room from sliding, and it keeps your streak alive. The Daily 1 fully counts.

● BRAIN NOTE

Daily systems often get boring for our brains after a couple of weeks. That's not you failing. It's novelty wearing off. When it happens, change the *flavor*, not the system: new playlist, new timer, a different body double, a race against a song, a "one-podcast-episode" rule. Same three resets, fresh packaging.

06

CHAPTER 6

Systems That Run Themselves

Seven small systems for the seven places mess loves most.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Mess gathers where a system is missing. Each system here takes 15 minutes or less to set up, and makes the right thing the easy thing: a launch pad by the door, a laundry loop with alarms, a kitchen closing shift, a doom pile method, a 3-folder paper system, a bathroom wipe station, and a home for "worn once" clothes.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- System 1: The Launch Pad
- System 2: The Laundry Loop
- System 3: The Kitchen Closing Shift
- System 4: Dismantling Doom Piles
- System 5: Paper & Mail
- System 6: The Bathroom 2-Minute Wipe
- System 7: The Bedroom & the Clothes Chair

This chapter is a toolbox. You don't need all seven systems at once. **Pick the one that fixes your most annoying daily problem** and start there. Each one follows the same format:

- **The problem** (you'll recognize it)
- **The system** (how it works)
- **Set it up** (15 minutes or less)
- **Keep it going** (tiny daily habit)
- **When it breaks** (because it will, and that's fine)

System 1

The Launch Pad

The problem: You lose your keys, wallet, or phone at least twice a week. Stuff you bring home spreads through the house. The mornings are chaos.

The system: one spot, right where you walk in, where everything that goes in and out of the house lives. Your house's airport gate.

Set it up (15 minutes):

- ☐ **Find the landing spot.** Where does your stuff *already* land when you walk in? That's where the launch pad goes. Even if it's the kitchen counter.
- ☐ **A bowl or tray** for keys, wallet, sunglasses, earbuds.
- ☐ **A hook** (or two) for your bag and coat. Hooks, not hangers.
- ☐ **A charging spot** for your phone, if there's an outlet nearby.
- ☐ **An OUT basket** for anything that needs to leave the house: returns, borrowed stuff, library books, things to mail.
- ☐ **A shoe zone:** a tray, a mat, or a basket.
- ☐ **Labels on everything.** KEYS. OUT. SHOES.

Keep it going: every time you walk in, **everything in hand goes onto the pad before you do anything else.** Every night, the 2-minute Tomorrow-You Prep (page 35).

When it breaks: if the pad keeps overflowing, it's too small or too far from the door. Move it closer. Add a second hook. And if stuff lands somewhere else consistently, *move the pad there.* Your habits are the boss.

● BRAIN NOTE

A launch pad works because it removes the "where does this go?" decision at the exact moment you're most distracted: walking in the door, arms full, already thinking about dinner.

System 2

The Laundry Loop

The problem: Wet clothes forgotten in the washer (again). A clean-laundry mountain on the couch. Nothing to wear, but a lot of clothes.

The system: one load, all the way, in one day, with alarms doing the remembering for you.

Set it up (15 minutes):

- ☐ **A hamper where clothes come off.** Usually the bedroom and the bathroom. Not in a closet with a door.
- ☐ **Two hampers (or one divided one):** darks and lights. That's all the sorting you'll ever need to do.
- ☐ **No-fold bins or drawers** for underwear, socks, pajamas, gym clothes, kids' clothes, towels.
- ☐ **Hangers near the dryer or rack**, so shirts go straight onto hangers, skipping the folding step.
- ☐ **A "laundry day" alarm on your phone**, if you like fixed days.

Keep it going, the loop in five beats:

- 1. Start** a load when a hamper is full (morning is great).
- 2. Alarm** named "WET CLOTHES" the moment you press start.
- 3. Switch** to the dryer or rack. New alarm: "DRY CLOTHES".
- 4. Hang or toss** straight into no-fold bins. Fold only what really needs it.
- 5. Put away.** The load isn't done until it's in the drawer.

When it breaks: clean-laundry mountain again? Don't fold it. Sort it into people or categories into baskets, and treat those baskets as "drawers" for the week. Then restart the loop with *one* load. Also: if the washer is far away (a shared basement, a laundromat), pick a fixed day and pair it with a podcast or a friend.

● TRY THIS NOW

Open your phone's alarm app and create two alarms, turned off, named **WET CLOTHES** and **DRY CLOTHES**. Next time you start a load, turn one on. No remembering needed.

System 3

The Kitchen Closing Shift

The problem: You wake up to last night's dishes. Cooking breakfast means cleaning first. The kitchen sets the mood for the whole day, and the mood is "ugh."

The system: a fixed 5-step closing shift, done at the same point every evening.

Set it up (10 minutes):

- ☐ **Clear the "dish drop" spot:** the counter next to the sink. That's where dirty dishes wait during the day.
- ☐ **Soap, a brush, and a cloth** within arm's reach of the sink.
- ☐ **An empty dishwasher** (or drying rack) to start. An empty dishwasher is a place for dirty dishes to go all day instead of the sink.
- ☐ **Tape the 5 steps** on the inside of a cabinet door.

The closing shift:

1. Dishes in
2. Counters cleared
3. Counters and stovetop wiped
4. Sink empty, dishwasher running if full
5. "Kitchen closed": fresh towel, light off

Keep it going: glue it to the end of dinner, and **unload the dishwasher in the morning** while the coffee brews. (Time it once. It's often under five minutes.)

When it breaks: skipped a few nights and now it's a disaster? Do the **Day 1 kitchen plan** (page 21) once, then go back to the closing shift. Tiny kitchen, no dishwasher? Wash in batches: all cups, then all plates, then all cutlery. Big family? Split the steps: someone clears, someone loads, someone wipes.

System 4

Dismantling Doom Piles

The problem: Piles. On the dining table, the stairs, the corner of the bedroom. They grow quietly. They're full of mystery items, a few important papers, and a lot of guilt.

The system: a fast, no-thinking method to dismantle one pile at a time, and a legal "doom basket" to stop new ones.

Set it up: grab your 5 bins (TRASH, DONATE, ELSEWHERE, KEEP, MAYBE) and a timer.

The method: top-down, ten at a time.

1. **Set a 10-minute timer.** One pile. Never "all the piles."
2. **Start from the top.** Pick up one thing.
3. **Decide in 10 seconds** (use the scripts on page 48). Drop it in a bin.
4. **No side quests.** No reading letters, no testing pens, no trying things on. Anything that needs more than 10 seconds goes to MAYBE.
5. **Every 10 items, pause** and take the trash bag out if it's full. Movement helps.
6. **When the timer rings: stop.** Date the MAYBE box. Deliver ELSEWHERE.

● THE LEGAL DOOM BASKET

Doom piles happen because our brains need somewhere to put things *right now* when there's no obvious home. So give yourself one **official doom basket** per floor. It's allowed to be messy. The only rule: it gets emptied once a week, during the Sunday Reset (page 56). A contained doom basket beats five wild doom piles.

When it breaks: if the same kind of item keeps showing up in your piles (chargers, receipts, kids' art), that item needs a home. Make one, label it, and that pile shrinks forever.

System 5

Paper & Mail

The problem: Mail piles up. Bills get lost. You've paid at least one late fee purely because an envelope blended into the counter.

The system: open mail standing over the recycling bin, and sort into **three visible folders**. That's all.

Set it up (15 minutes):

- ☐ **A standing file or wall pocket** near where mail lands (visible beats hidden, remember).
- ☐ **Three folders, bright colors, big labels: ACT** (forms, appointments, things to do), **PAY** (bills), **KEEP** (important: tax stuff, warranties, records).
- ☐ **A recycling bin right there**, and a bag for anything to shred.
- ☐ **A pen and sticky notes** clipped nearby.

Keep it going:

- **Daily:** open the mail over the recycling bin. Junk goes straight in. Everything else goes in a folder. Two minutes.
- **Weekly, during the Sunday Reset:** a 10-minute "paper date." Pay what's in PAY. Do or schedule what's in ACT. Move KEEP items into a real file box (or snap a photo if a digital copy is enough).
- **Switch to paperless** for any bill you can. One less envelope to lose.

When it breaks: if the folders overflow, you've skipped a few paper dates. No problem. Set a timer for 15 minutes and deal with PAY first. Bills with dates come before everything else.

● **TRY THIS NOW**

Walk to your mail pile with a recycling bag. Set a timer for 5 minutes. Recycle every obvious piece of junk mail, unopened. Watch the pile shrink by half.

System 6

The Bathroom 2-Minute Wipe

The problem: The bathroom goes from fine to "please don't come in here" surprisingly fast. Cleaning it feels like a Big Job, so it waits until it really is one.

The system: a tiny wipe every day, with supplies that live **in the bathroom**, in plain sight.

Set it up (10 minutes):

- ☐ **Wipes or a spray and cloth** under the sink or in a caddy on the counter.
- ☐ **A toilet brush with a holder** next to the toilet, plus a toilet cleaner that stays in the room.
- ☐ **A spare roll of toilet paper** where you can reach it from the toilet. (A basket works.)
- ☐ **A small trash can with a liner** and spare liners stored at the bottom of the can.
- ☐ **A hook for the towel**, not a rail. Hooks are easier.

The 2-minute wipe (after evening teeth-brushing):

1. Wipe the sink and faucet
2. Wipe the toilet seat and rim, then flush
3. Toothpaste, brush, and stuff back in their spots

Keep it going: glue it to brushing your teeth. Once a week, during the Sunday Reset, swap the towels and swish the toilet bowl.

When it breaks: skipped a week? Do Round 1 of Day 6 (page 21). It takes 15 minutes, and then you're back to the 2-minute wipe.

System 7

The Bedroom & the Clothes Chair

The problem: The chair (or the floor, or the end of the bed) is buried in clothes. The bed is never made. The nightstand is a museum of water glasses.

The system: a home for "worn once" clothes, a 30-second bed, and a nightstand tray.

Set it up (15 minutes):

- ☐ **A WEAR AGAIN home:** hooks on the wall or door, or one open basket.
- ☐ **A hamper** where you take clothes off (not across the room).
- ☐ **A tray** on the nightstand for the small bits.
- ☐ **A "bedroom exit" spot** by the door for cups and dishes that need to go to the kitchen in the morning.

Keep it going:

- **The 30-second bed:** pull up the duvet, toss the pillows. That's a made bed. (Many people skip the top sheet entirely. You're allowed.)

- **Clothes off, clothes placed:** hamper, WEAR AGAIN, or hanger. Three options, no thinking.
- **Morning cup run:** anything in the bedroom exit spot goes to the kitchen when you do.

When it breaks: the chair fills up again? That's normal. Once a week, do Round 2 of Day 5 (page 21): three piles, 12 minutes. Some weeks the chair wins. It's still a chair.

● SAY IT LIKE THIS

"The chair isn't a failure. It's a signal that my clothes need an easier home."

07

CHAPTER 7

The 5-Bin Declutter

Five bins, ten seconds per thing, zero arguments with a sock.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Work in 10-minute rounds on one small area (a shelf, not a room). Pick up each thing, decide in 10 seconds, and drop it in one of five bins: **Trash, Donate, Elsewhere, Keep, Maybe**. Stuck? Use a decision script, or it goes in Maybe. Trash and donations leave the house the same day.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The five bins
- How to do a round
- Decision scripts (for when you're stuck)
- The tricky categories
- Getting it out the door

Decluttering is where a lot of us get stuck, because every single object asks for a decision, and decisions are the most tiring part. The 5-bin method solves that with **pre-made decisions**: only five possible answers, and a script for every hard one.

The five bins

TRASH	Broken, expired, stained, mystery cables with no device. Also recycling.
DONATE	Good condition, but not for you anymore. Someone else will love it.
ELSEWHERE	Keeping it, but it lives in another room. Delivered at the end.
KEEP	Stays here, and has (or gets) a home in this space.
MAYBE	Can't decide in 10 seconds. Box it, date it, decide later (or never).

Use boxes, bags, laundry baskets, anything. Label them with masking tape. **Labels matter**: when you're mid-round and tired, you want to drop, not think.

How to do a round

1. **Pick a tiny area.** One shelf. One drawer. One corner of the counter. **Not a room.** Rooms are for Future You.
2. **Set a timer for 10 minutes.** Put on music.
3. **Pick up one thing.** Decide in about 10 seconds. Drop it in a bin.
4. **Repeat** until the timer rings or the area is clear.
5. **Close out (5 minutes):** Trash out to the bin outside. Donate bag straight into your car or by the front door. Deliver ELSEWHERE. Date the MAYBE box and put it away.
6. **Celebrate.** Photo of the clear shelf. Yes, even a tiny shelf.

● THE MAYBE BOX IS A SECRET WEAPON

The Maybe box takes the pressure off. You don't have to decide *forever* right now. Write today's date on it and put it somewhere out of the way. **If you haven't opened it or missed anything in 60 days, donate it unopened.** Your brain already made the decision for you by forgetting it existed.

Decision scripts (for when you're stuck)

Hold the thing. Read one question. Answer honestly. Drop it in a bin. If none of these work in 10 seconds: Maybe.

"If I lost this today, would I buy it again?"

No? Donate or trash.

"Have I used this in the last year?"

No, and it's not seasonal or an emergency thing? Donate.

"Do I have another one that's better?"

Keep the better one. Donate the spare.

"Is this for the me I am, or the me I think I'll become someday?"

Keep things for the you who lives here now.

"Am I keeping this out of guilt?"

Gifts, expensive mistakes. The money is already spent. Letting go doesn't waste it twice.

"Would I pay to move this to a new home?"

If you'd leave it behind in a move, you can leave it behind now.

"Does it have a home here?"

No home and no room for one? That's a strong vote for letting go.

"Would I be happy if a friend took this?"

Yes? Donate. You've already let it go in your heart.

The tricky categories

"But I might need it someday." Try the *under-20 rule*: if you could replace it for less than about \$20 in less than about 20 minutes, and you haven't used it in a year, it can go. You're trading a small, unlikely cost for a lot of space.

Sentimental things. Don't start here. Sentimental items are the hardest decisions of all, so save them until the easy stuff has warmed you up. When you do: keep the best few, take photos of the rest, and give the special ones a **memory box** with a size limit. The box decides how much you keep, not guilt.

Gifts. A gift's job was done the moment it was given. You're allowed to thank it and pass it on.

The "I'll sell it" pile. Selling takes photos, listings, messages, and meetups. That's a lot of steps for our brains. If you want to sell something, give it a **deadline**: listed within a week, sold within a month, or it goes to donate. No hard feelings.

Hobby supplies for hobbies you don't do anymore. Keep one small box for the hobby you're *actually* likely to pick up again. Donate the rest to a school, art program, or someone who's new to it.

Other people's stuff. Not yours to declutter. Put it in an ELSEWHERE pile for them, or ask. (See Chapter 11 for kind ways to talk about it.)

● SAY IT LIKE THIS (TO YOURSELF, WHILE HOLDING A HARD ONE)

"Thank you for being part of my life. You can go be useful to someone else now."

It sounds silly. It works more often than you'd think.

Getting it out the door

A donate bag sitting by your front door for three months is a doom pile in a bag.

- **Donations go in the car immediately.** Next time you drive past a donation spot, you're ready.
- **Trash leaves the same day.** All the way to the outside bin.
- **Set a "drop-off date"** in your phone for this week.
- **No car?** Many areas have charity pickups, buy-nothing groups, or neighbors happy to take things. One message, and it's gone.

08

CHAPTER 8

Energy Menus

Match the task to the battery you have today, not the one you wish you had.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Check your energy first, then pick from the matching menu. Low energy? Choose a sit-down task. Medium? A 10-minute one. High? A timed round on something big. **Every menu item counts.** Doing a low-energy task on a low-energy day is the system working.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Step one: check your battery
- The Low-Energy Menu
- The Medium-Energy Menu
- The High-Energy Menu
- Make it fun: the dopamine add-ons

Most cleaning plans assume you have the same energy every day. You don't. None of us do. Some days you could reorganize the garage. Some days, getting a glass of water feels like a mountain.

Energy menus let you **still make progress on every kind of day**, by picking from a list that matches what you actually have.

Step one: check your battery

Before you start, ask: *"What's my battery at right now?"*



Low

Tired, foggy, sad, sick, overwhelmed. Sitting down sounds great.



Medium

Okay-ish. Can do a thing or two if it's short.



High

Restless, buzzy, motivated. Let's use it before it's gone.

The Low-Energy Menu

2 to 5 minutes each. Many can be done sitting down. Pick one. Any one.

- ☐ Put all the dishes within reach into one stack
- ☐ Throw away the trash you can reach from the couch
- ☐ Open the mail over a recycling bag
- ☐ Match socks while watching TV
- ☐ Wipe the bathroom sink with a wipe
- ☐ Put five things back where they belong
- ☐ Clear only the nightstand
- ☐ Fold one blanket and fluff the couch cushions
- ☐ Take the trash bag to the door (not outside, only the door)
- ☐ Unload only the cutlery from the dishwasher
- ☐ Make the bed the 30-second way
- ☐ Order groceries online instead of going out
- ☐ Put on clean pajamas and change the pillowcase
- ☐ Charge your phone at the launch pad
- ☐ Write tomorrow's one important thing on a sticky note
- ☐ Refill the soap
- ☐ Spray the shower and walk away (the spray does the work)
- ☐ Put your chaos basket by the stairs for tomorrow

The Medium-Energy Menu

About 10 minutes each. Timer on, music on.

- ☐ The Kitchen Closing Shift
- ☐ The 10-Minute Tidy of one room
- ☐ Start a load of laundry and set the WET CLOTHES alarm
- ☐ Put away one basket of clean laundry
- ☐ Clear and wipe the dining table
- ☐ The bathroom 2-minute wipe, plus a toilet swish
- ☐ Declutter one drawer with the 5 bins
- ☐ Empty the fridge of anything expired
- ☐ Take out all the trash and recycling
- ☐ Empty the chaos basket or doom basket
- ☐ The 10-minute paper date
- ☐ Vacuum or sweep one room (only the middle, skip the corners)
- ☐ Wipe the stovetop and microwave
- ☐ Change the sheets (it counts as two tasks)

The High-Energy Menu

Three or four 15-minute rounds, with breaks. Ride the wave, but stop before you crash.

- ☐ Any day from the 7-Day Reset
- ☐ Dismantle one doom pile
- ☐ Laundry to zero-ish (the full loop, with alarms)
- ☐ Declutter one closet shelf or one kitchen cabinet
- ☐ Clean out the car
- ☐ Deep clean one thing (the oven, the shower, the fridge shelves)
- ☐ Set up a new system from Chapter 6
- ☐ Take the donate bags to the drop-off
- ☐ Rearrange a space so things live where you use them
- ☐ The full Sunday Reset

● BRAIN NOTE: THE HIGH-ENERGY CRASH

High-energy days are precious, and it's tempting to use every last drop. But doing *everything* often leads to a crash the next day, and then several days of nothing. Try this: **when you feel the energy start to dip, do one more small task, then stop.** Leave some battery for tomorrow.

Make it fun: the dopamine add-ons

Add one of these to any menu item to make it easier to start:

- **Race a song.** Can you finish before it ends?
- **The "only while cleaning" podcast.** A show you save exclusively for chores.
- **Call a friend** on speaker while you tidy.
- **A clean-with-me video** as a body double.
- **The reward first.** Pour the nice drink, then clean while you sip it.
- **Put on "going out" music** and pretend you're getting the house ready for a party.
- **Make it a game:** pick up 10 things of one color, or 15 things in 5 minutes.
- **Change the scenery:** new cleaning spray scent, a fun cloth, a timer that looks cute.

● TRY THIS NOW

Copy the Low-Energy Menu onto a sticky note (or print the fridge version at the back of this book). The next time you feel stuck on the couch, pick one item. Only one.

09

CHAPTER 9

The Sunday Reset

One weekly hour (in pieces) that makes Monday feel possible.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Once a week, do seven short resets: brain dump, whole-house sweep, laundry, fridge check, paper date, week look-ahead, and set up Monday. About an hour in total, split into rounds you can spread across the day. On a hard week, the 15-minute mini reset is enough.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The seven steps
- Make it something you look forward to

The Daily 3 keeps things from snowballing. The Sunday Reset catches everything that slipped through the cracks during the week, and helps you walk into Monday feeling like you're on top of things. (It doesn't have to be Sunday. Choose any day that works.)

The seven steps

STEP	WHAT YOU DO
1. Brain dump 5 min	Write down everything in your head: tasks, worries, things to buy, things to remember. It doesn't need to be organized. The goal is to get it out of your brain and onto paper.
2. House sweep 10 min	Walk through every room with the chaos basket and a trash bag. Trash out, stray stuff into the basket. Then deliver everything. Empty the doom basket too.
3. Laundry 5 min	Strip the bed, gather towels, start a load. Alarm on. (The rest of the laundry loop happens in the background.)
4. Fridge check 10 min	Toss anything expired or fuzzy. Wipe one shelf. Look at what's there, and make your grocery list from it.
5. Paper date 10 min	Open your ACT and PAY folders. Pay the bills, handle or schedule the tasks, file the KEEP items.
6. Week look-ahead 10 min	Check the calendar. Note any appointments, deadlines, birthdays. Pick three easy dinners. Put reminders in your phone.
7. Set up Monday 5 min	Launch pad ready. Clothes picked. Bag packed. Kitchen closed. Fresh sheets on the bed. Go to bed feeling looked after.

● BRAIN NOTE

You don't have to do this in one go. Many of us do steps 1 to 3 in the morning, 4 and 5 after lunch, and 6 and 7 in the evening. **Spreading it out is not cheating.** It's working with your battery instead of against it.

Make it something you look forward to

The Sunday Reset works best when it feels like a ritual, not a punishment. Some ideas:

- A special "**Sunday Reset**" **playlist** or podcast
- Your favorite **drink** or a **snack** that only exists on reset day
- A **candle** or fresh flowers once the house sweep is done
- A **body double**: a friend on video, doing their reset at the same time
- A **reward** at the end: a bath, a show, a walk, a nap

● THE 15-MINUTE MINI RESET

For hard weeks, do only three things: **(1)** a 5-minute brain dump, **(2)** a 5-minute house sweep with the chaos basket, **(3)** 5 minutes setting up Monday at the launch pad. That's a Sunday Reset. It counts.

● TRY THIS NOW

Pick your reset day and put a recurring reminder in your phone for it. Name it something kind, like *"Sunday Reset: future me says thanks."*

10

CHAPTER 10

Fell Off the Wagon? The Restart Protocol

There is no wagon. There's only today, and one small thing.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Don't catch up. Start from today. Name what happened without shame, do one 15-minute reset of the kitchen, then do only the Daily 1 for three days before going back to the Daily 3. Every restart is practice, and you'll get faster at it every time.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The 5-step restart
- Find the leak (only if you want to)
- Hard-week mode
- Why every restart is easier than the last

Let's get this out of the way: **you will fall off**. Everybody does. You'll get sick, or busy, or sad, or distracted by a new hobby, and one day you'll look up and the house will look like Week Zero again.

That's not the system failing. **Restarting is part of the system**. People with tidy homes aren't people who never fall off. They're people who get back on quickly. And getting back on is a skill you can practice.

The 5-step restart

- 1 Name it, kindly.** Say out loud (or in your head): *"Things slid. That makes sense. I'm restarting today."* No lecture. No autopsy. The house doesn't care why, and neither do we.
- 2 Drop the backlog.** You are not catching up on three weeks of chores. That list doesn't exist anymore. Today is Day 1 again, and Day 1 is small.
- 3 Reset one room: the kitchen.** Do the 15-minute kitchen reset (Day 1 minimum version, page 21). The kitchen is the fastest way to make the whole house feel like it's back under control.
- 4 Three days of the Daily 1.** Only dishes in. Nothing else required. Three days in a row gets momentum rolling without draining your battery.
- 5 Then add the Daily 3 back.** One reset at a time if you like. Add the Sunday Reset when it feels possible.

● SAY IT LIKE THIS (TO YOURSELF)

"I'm not starting over. I'm starting again, with everything I learned last time."

Find the leak (only if you want to)

Once you're back on, it can help to notice *what* knocked the system over. Not to blame yourself, but to patch the hole for next time.

WHAT HAPPENED	TRY THIS NEXT TIME
I got sick or had a hard week	Switch straight to the Daily 1 the moment you notice. Plan for "hard-week mode" (below).
My schedule changed (new job, holidays, travel)	Re-glue your Daily 3 to new habits. The old glue stopped working.
I got bored of it	Change the flavor: new playlist, body double, timer, or reward. Same system, new packaging.
One zone kept overflowing	That zone needs a system or a bigger home. Check Chapter 6.
I tried to do too much and crashed	Go back to minimum versions for a week. Small and steady wins.
I honestly don't know	That's okay. You don't need to know to restart.

Hard-week mode

Some weeks aren't about a tidy home. They're about getting through. Illness, grief, burnout, a new baby, a big deadline. For those weeks, the goal shrinks to **safe and sanitary**, and everything else is optional.

● HARD-WEEK PERMISSION SLIP

You are allowed to:

- Use paper plates and disposable cups
- Live out of the clean laundry basket
- Order groceries, order food, eat cereal for dinner
- Close the doors of rooms you can't deal with
- Ask someone for help (see the scripts in the next chapter)
- Do only the Daily 1, or nothing, and restart when the week is over

The only goals: trash out, food not spoiling, and a clear spot to sleep.

● A GENTLE NOTE

If the mess is part of a bigger feeling (like everything being hard, all the time, for a long time), you deserve support with that too. A doctor, therapist, or someone you trust is a great place to start. Needing help isn't a failure. It's a smart move.

Why every restart is easier than the last

The first time you do the 7-Day Reset, you're building systems from nothing. The second time, the launch pad already exists. The laundry alarms are already in your phone. The Maybe box is already dated.

Every restart starts from a higher floor. You never go all the way back to zero. Even on the messiest day, you know how to get out.

11

CHAPTER 11

Living With Other Humans

Partners, roommates, and kids. Systems beat nagging, every time.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Make the system do the asking. Labels, visible homes, and simple shared resets help everyone put things away without anyone nagging. Agree on a small "shared space baseline," divide jobs by ownership (not "helping"), and use kind, specific scripts when you need to talk about it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Four principles for a shared home
- The shared space baseline
- Scripts for partners
- Roommates
- Kids
- When nobody agrees

Other people make everything more complicated. They have their own stuff, their own standards, and their own brains. Sometimes you're the messy one. Sometimes they are. Often, it's both of you, in different ways.

The good news: **everything in this book works better with more people, not worse.** Labels, visible homes, and short timed resets are easy for anyone to follow, including kids and people who swear they "don't see mess."

Four principles for a shared home

- 1. Systems beat nagging.** A labeled basket that says SHOES reminds people to put their shoes away without you saying a word. Every time you catch yourself reminding someone of the same thing, ask: *"What system could remind them instead?"*
- 2. Agree on a baseline, not a standard.** People will never agree on "clean." But you can agree on a short list of things that are true in shared spaces most of the time.
- 3. Own, don't help.** "Can you help with the dishes?" makes one person the manager. "You own the kitchen closing shift on weeknights" gives someone a whole job, from start to finish.
- 4. Assume a different brain, not bad intentions.** Your partner leaving socks on the floor is probably not a message. It's probably a missing hamper.

The shared space baseline

Sit down together for 15 minutes (with snacks) and agree on **three to five things** that will be true in shared spaces by the end of each day. For example:

- ☐ No dishes left outside the kitchen overnight
- ☐ Kitchen closing shift done every night (rotating)
- ☐ Shoes and bags on the launch pad, not the floor
- ☐ Living room floor clear before bed
- ☐ Bathroom counter wiped after the evening routine

Keep it short. Five things everyone can do beats twenty that nobody does. Write the list down and stick it somewhere visible.

Scripts for partners

● WHEN YOU WANT TO BRING IT UP (WITHOUT A FIGHT)

"Hey, I've been reading about ways to make the house easier for both of us. Can we pick a time this week to talk about it for 15 minutes? I'll bring snacks."

● WHEN YOU'RE THE MESSIER ONE

"I know my stuff ends up everywhere, and I'm working on it. It's not that I don't care. My brain really doesn't see it. Would it help if we set up a basket for my things in the living room, so there's one spot instead of ten?"

● WHEN THEY'RE THE MESSIER ONE

"I've noticed your [bag / shoes / mugs] end up in [place] a lot. What if we made that their official spot? I'll put a basket there. Would that work for you?"

● WHEN YOU NEED HELP ON A HARD DAY

"I'm running on empty today. Could you take the kitchen tonight? I'll take it tomorrow."

Roommates

Roommates are trickier, because you're sharing space without sharing a life. Keep things clear and light:

- **Divide by zone, not by task.** "You own the bathroom, I own the kitchen" is easier than splitting every chore.
- **Rotate monthly** so nobody gets stuck with the worst job forever.
- **Label shared shelves** in the fridge and cupboards. Clear boundaries are kind.
- **Weekly 10-minute check-in** (or a group chat reminder) instead of passive-aggressive notes.

● SAY IT LIKE THIS (TO A ROOMMATE)

"Hey, I'm trying out a new cleaning system and it'd be easier with a plan. Want to pick zones? I'm happy to take the kitchen if you take the bathroom, and we swap next month."

Kids

Kids are mess-makers by design, but they're also surprisingly good at systems when the systems are simple and visible.

- **Picture labels on bins** for kids who can't read yet. A photo of a car on the car bin.
- **Fewer toys out at once.** Rotate a few bins every couple of weeks. Less stuff means less mess, and "old" toys feel new again.
- **Make tidy-up a race.** One song, everyone tidies, the house is reset before the song ends.
- **Pair jobs with routines:** shoes on the launch pad when you walk in, dirty clothes in the hamper at bath time.

AGE (ROUGHLY)	JOBS THEY CAN OFTEN OWN
3 to 5	Toys into bins, shoes to the launch pad, clothes into the hamper, wipe the table with help
6 to 9	Make their bed (30-second style), set and clear the table, match socks, feed a pet, empty small trash cans
10 to 13	Load or unload the dishwasher, run a load of laundry with you, the 10-Minute Tidy of their room
14+	Own a full zone or a nightly kitchen closing shift, do their own laundry loop

Every kid is different (and some kids have ADHD brains too). Adjust freely. The goal is **ownership, not perfection.**

● SAY IT LIKE THIS (TO KIDS)

"It's reset time! Let's see if we can get every toy in its bin before this song ends.
Ready? Go!"

And after: "Look at that floor! You did that."

When nobody agrees

Sometimes, despite everyone's best efforts, you'll have different ideas of what "clean" means. A few things that help:

- **Give each person one "no-rules zone"** (a desk, a corner, their side of the bedroom) where their own standards apply.
- **Focus on shared spaces only.** What happens in someone's own room is their business.
- **Try the "whoever cares most" deal:** if you care about something more (say, a clear dining table), it can be your zone, and they take something else.
- **Outsource if you can,** even one deep clean a season. It can save a lot of arguments.

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CHAPTER 12

Your 30-Day Restart Calendar

A month of tiny steps. Cross off days, not perfection.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Week 1 is the 7-Day Reset. Week 2 installs the Daily 3. Week 3 is small declutter rounds. Week 4 locks in the Sunday Reset and your people. Each day's task is 15 minutes or less. Missed a day? Skip it. Don't double up.

Here's the whole month on one page. Print it, put it on the fridge, and **cross off each day you do anything at all**. The Daily 3 runs quietly in the background from Day 8 onward.

1 Kit day: gather your reset caddy (Day 0) ☐	2 Kitchen: sink & counters ☐	3 Living room: floor & couch ☐	4 Launch pad by the door ☐	5 Laundry: one load, all the way ☐
6 Bedroom & the clothes chair ☐	7 Bathroom + paper pile ☐	8 Doom pile + victory lap. Choose your Daily 3! ☐	9 Daily 3 starts. Kitchen Closing Shift tonight ☐	10 Set WET CLOTHES + DRY CLOTHES alarms ☐
11 Build the "wear again" home ☐	12 Set up ACT / PAY / KEEP folders ☐	13 Couch caddy + "Going That Way" basket ☐	14 First Sunday Reset (mini version is fine) ☐	15 Declutter: one kitchen drawer ☐
16 Declutter: bathroom counter + cabinet ☐	17 Declutter: one shelf of your closet ☐	18 Declutter: the fridge (expired stuff) ☐	19 Declutter: your bag or car ☐	20 Declutter: one doom pile (10 min) ☐
21 Donations out the door. Celebrate! ☐	22 Time it once: pick a dreaded task and time it ☐	23 Write your Energy Menu on the fridge ☐	24 Label three homes that don't have labels ☐	25 Shared space baseline chat (15 min) ☐
26 Pick a body double for the week ☐	27 Sunday Reset (full or mini) ☐	28 Emergency Reset practice run (15 min) ☐	29 "After" photos + compare to Day 1 ☐	30 Pick your favorite system. You did a month! ☐

Days 1–8: The 7–Day Reset (+ kit day)

Days 9–14: Daily 3 + systems

Days 15–21: Declutter rounds

Days 22–30: Lock it in

PRINT & STICK

Printables

Print them, stick them on the fridge, tick the boxes.

IF YOU ONLY READ ONE THING

Print only the pages you'll use. The Quick Start card goes on the fridge. The Emergency Reset goes inside a cabinet door. The Daily 3 tracker and Sunday Reset checklist work great in a sheet protector with a dry-erase marker, so you can reuse them every week.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The Quick Start Card
- The 15-Minute Emergency Reset
- The Daily 3 Tracker
- The Sunday Reset Checklist
- The 7-Day Reset Tracker
- The Energy Menu (fridge version)

The Quick Start Card

For when your brain is full. Five steps, fifteen minutes.

- 1 **Timer on:** 15 minutes, one song you love.
- 2 **Trash bag:** pick up only trash in this room.
- 3 **Basket:** everything that doesn't live here goes in.
- 4 **One surface:** clear it completely and wipe it.
- 5 **Stop at the timer.** Look at your clear surface. That counts.

1

Reset, don't deep
clean

2

Visible beats hidden

3

Homes for everything,
labels on the homes

4

Done beats perfect

5

Touch it once

6

Body double + timer

Missed a day? Don't catch up. Start from today, small.

The 15-Minute Emergency Reset

Someone's coming over. Only clean what they'll see.

- ☐ **0:00** Walk the guest path: door, sitting spot, bathroom
- ☐ **1:00** Trash bag sweep along the guest path
- ☐ **4:00** Chaos basket sweep: floor first, then surfaces. Hide the basket
- ☐ **8:00** Dishes into the sink or dishwasher. Hot soapy water on top
- ☐ **10:00** Bathroom: toilet swish, wipe seat and sink, fresh hand towel
- ☐ **12:00** Wipe the table they'll sit at. Fluff cushions. Fold a blanket
- ☐ **14:00** Lamps on, big lights off, window open, music on
- ☐ **15:00** Breathe. Say *"Come in! Want tea?"*

5-minute version: chaos basket on the floor and coffee table · dishes in the sink · toilet swish + fresh towel · lamps on.

Aftercare: empty the chaos basket within 48 hours.

The Daily 3 Tracker

Tick what you did. One out of three is a great day.

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
1. Kitchen Closing Shift Dishes in, counters clear, wipe, sink empty, kitchen closed							
2. 10-Minute Tidy Trash, dishes, floor, surfaces, deliver							
3. Tomorrow-You Prep Keys, bag, OUT basket, one thing set out							
Daily 1 (rough day) Dishes in. That's it.							

My glue for #1: _____

My glue for #2: _____

My glue for #3: _____

Days with at least one reset this week: ____ / 7

The Sunday Reset Checklist

About an hour, in pieces. Any day of the week works.

- ☐ **Brain dump** (5 min): everything in your head onto paper
- ☐ **House sweep** (10 min): chaos basket + trash bag through every room, then deliver. Empty the doom basket
- ☐ **Laundry** (5 min): strip the bed, gather towels, start a load, alarm on
- ☐ **Fridge check** (10 min): toss expired stuff, wipe a shelf, write the grocery list
- ☐ **Paper date** (10 min): pay the PAY folder, handle the ACT folder, file KEEP
- ☐ **Week look-ahead** (10 min): calendar, appointments, three easy dinners
- ☐ **Set up Monday** (5 min): launch pad ready, clothes out, bag packed, fresh sheets

Mini reset (hard weeks, 15 min): 5-min brain dump · 5-min house sweep · 5-min Monday setup.

BRAIN DUMP SPACE

The 7-Day Reset Tracker

Minimum version counts. Skipped days are allowed. Never double up.

DAY	ZONE	MINIMUM	STANDARD	PHOTO
0	Gather the reset kit			
1	Kitchen: sink & counters			
2	Living room: floor & couch			
3	Launch pad by the door			
4	Laundry to zero-ish			
5	Bedroom & clothes chair			
6	Bathroom + paper pile			
7	Doom pile + victory lap			

My Daily 3: _____

How I'll celebrate: _____

The Energy Menu (fridge version)

Check your battery. Pick one thing from the matching list.

Low

2–5 min, can sit down

- ☐ Stack dishes in reach
- ☐ Trash within reach
- ☐ Open mail over recycling
- ☐ Match socks + TV
- ☐ Wipe bathroom sink
- ☐ Put 5 things away
- ☐ Clear the nightstand
- ☐ 30-second bed
- ☐ Refill the soap

Medium

about 10 min

- ☐ Kitchen Closing Shift
- ☐ 10-Minute Tidy
- ☐ Start laundry + alarm
- ☐ Put away one basket
- ☐ Clear the table
- ☐ Declutter one drawer
- ☐ Fridge expiry check
- ☐ Trash + recycling out
- ☐ Paper date

High

15-min rounds + breaks

- ☐ A 7-Day Reset day
- ☐ One doom pile
- ☐ Laundry to zero-ish
- ☐ A closet shelf
- ☐ Clean out the car
- ☐ Deep clean one thing
- ☐ Set up a new system
- ☐ Donation drop-off
- ☐ Full Sunday Reset

Dopamine add-ons: race a song · cleaning-only podcast · call a friend · clean-with-me video · reward first · make it a game

You Did a Thing.

Whether you read every page or only the Quick Start, whether you did all seven days or one minimum version: **you picked this up because you wanted life at home to feel easier.**

That's the hardest step, and you already did it.

Here's what to remember when the book is back on the shelf:

- **Mess is information, not a verdict.** It shows you where a system is missing.
- **Small counts.** A minimum version is a full win.
- **Timers make things finite.** Body doubles make things possible.
- **Visible beats hidden.** Labels do the remembering.
- **There's no wagon.** Only today, and one small thing.

Your home doesn't have to be perfect to be a good home. It has to work for the people who live in it, **including you, with your beautiful, busy, messy brain.**

● WANT THE TOOLS?

Many of the things mentioned in this book (clear bins, visual timers, wall pockets, hooks, label makers) are totally optional. A cardboard box with masking tape works fine too. But if you'd like ideas, see the tools list at modernpinkpaper.github.io/tools.

With love and a very full chaos basket,

Messy Brain, Tidy Home